

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Investors are fearful that** some market gains are outpacing typical measures of underlying value after strong economic growth helped power the S&P 500 to multiple records in a long bull market. **A1**
- ◆ **European defense stocks** surged, buoyed by the prospect of higher military spending, while U.S. markets were closed for the Presidents Day holiday. **B8**
- ◆ **TSMC and Broadcom** are independently considering potential deals that would break Intel in two, though nothing has been submitted to the American chip maker, people familiar with the matter said. **B1**
- ◆ **Southwest Airlines** is slated to shed 15% of its corporate workforce, eliminating about 1,750 jobs in an effort to cut costs and streamline the carrier's operations. **B1**
- ◆ **BlueScope** sought an exemption from tariffs on its shipments of Australian-made steel to the U.S., hoping to win a reprieve it first enjoyed during Trump's first term. **B4**
- ◆ **Chinese tech giant** Tencent began tests to integrate homegrown DeepSeek's artificial-intelligence model into its Weixin messaging app. **B4**
- ◆ **London-listed Anglo American** said it would retain a 19.9% stake in Anglo American Platinum after its planned demerger this summer. **B8**
- ◆ **"Captain America: Brave New World"** triumphed over the weekend, earning a heroic \$100 million to take first place at the domestic box office. **B2**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Europe's main military** powers worked to reclaim a seat at the negotiating table after the Trump administration sidelined them from talks with Russia over the future of Ukraine and the Continent's broader security. **A1, A10**
- ◆ **Elon Musk's** Department of Government Efficiency sought access to data systems within the IRS that house personal taxpayer information, according to people familiar with the matter. **A1**
- ◆ **Gov. Hochul** suggested she would consider removing New York City Mayor Eric Adams from his post in light of turmoil in his administration after the Justice Department ordered prosecutors to drop their bribery case against the mayor. **A3**
- ◆ **Eleven people**, including a child, died in Kentucky over the weekend as heavy rain and wind washed out roads, flooded communities and denied power to thousands. **A3**
- ◆ **Trump's campaign** to remake the federal government reached the Supreme Court, with the Justice Department arguing that the president has the power to dismiss an executive-branch ethics watchdog. **A5**
- ◆ **Israel's military** said it would keep a presence in five strategic locations along its border with Lebanon past a deadline to remove troops as part of a ceasefire deal with Hezbollah. **A8**
- ◆ **Huntington Beach, Calif.**, has become a laboratory for Trump-style local governance, a self-declared "non-sanctuary city" dismantling policies deemed progressive. **A3**

JOURNAL REPORT

Workplace Technology: How our readers use AI at work. **R1-8**

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Delta Jet Flips Over in Toronto Crash Landing



COLE BURSTON/REUTERS

HARROWING SCENE: A Delta Air Lines regional plane carrying 80 passengers and crew from Minneapolis crash-landed Monday at Toronto's airport, resulting in 15 injuries. For video from the scene, scan the code with the article on **A12**.

Investors Spot Signs of Froth In Markets' Lengthy Bull Run

By KRISTAL HUR

Investors are fearful that some market gains are outpacing typical measures of underlying value after strong economic growth helped power the S&P 500 to record after record in a nearly two-year bull market.

Trade wars and DeepSeek's challenge to the AI boom have barely dented the enthusiasm. Meme stocks are back, options are on fire and bitcoin is trading around \$100,000. That makes some traders nervous, because rising speculation can lead to market imbalances that at times presage corrections.

“There have been signs of froth for a while,” said Seema Shah, chief global strategist at Principal Asset Management. “The market is vulnerable to disappointment.”

One source of concern: Ordinary investors are really bullish about a handful of popular companies.

Shares of Palantir Technologies, a highly popular stock among individual investors, surged 24% on Feb. 4 after the data-analytics company reported strong sales growth and robust demand for its artificial-intelligence products. Palantir's stock has jumped

roughly 58% this year and was last year's best performer in the S&P 500.

Traders are also bidding up shares of Strategy, formerly MicroStrategy, the software company turned bitcoin-buying machine.

The company's market capitalization was recently about \$87 billion, nearly twice the value of the bitcoins it holds.

Meme stocks have also jumped. Shares of GameStop, BlackBerry and online pet products retailer Chewy have all soared more than 90% over the past 12 months, according to FactSet.

“There's always stocks that

it's hard to understand what the market sees,” said Michael Brenner, asset-allocation strategist at FBB Capital Partners. “You are starting to see some of these things stack up. And then the question just becomes, are there enough of these things to tip the market over?”

Activity is surging in options contracts, which give traders the right to buy or sell a stock at a set price. Options are a popular play among traders seeking bigger payouts than traditional buy-and-hold investing. But those bets can quickly go south, too.

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Europe, Left Out Of Talks, Sounds Alarm

Macron convenes emergency meeting, with U.S., Russia set for Ukraine dialogue

PARIS—Europe's main military powers were working to reclaim a seat at the negotiating table after the Trump administration sidelined them from talks with Russia over the future of Ukraine and the Continent's broader security.

By Stacy Meichtry, Laurence Norman and Nick Kostov

President Emmanuel Macron held an emergency meeting of European leaders inside the Élysée Palace on Monday, after he held a 20-minute call with President Trump. The flurry of diplomacy aimed to show that Europe still has a role to play in resolving the Ukraine war—even as senior U.S. officials traveled to Saudi Arabia this week for direct talks with Russia.

Time is short for the Europeans. Senior Russian and U.S. officials are due to start talks on Tuesday in Riyadh. U.S. officials told the Europeans at the Munich Security Conference over the weekend that they didn't see a direct role for them in the negotiations. Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov echoed that view in comments on Monday.

Ukraine hasn't been invited to join Tuesday's discussions.

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- ◆ **Zelensky sees little chance for progress.....** A10
- ◆ **Sanctions on horizon for Putin's shadow fleet.....** A10
- ◆ **Defense rally pushes Europe stocks to highs... B8**

Musk Unit Presses To Access Sensitive IRS Data

By BRIAN SCHWARTZ

Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency is seeking access to data systems within the Internal Revenue Service that house personal taxpayer information, according to people familiar with the matter.

An agreement with the IRS could give the team access to the Integrated Data Retrieval System, these people explained. That system, according to the IRS, allows anyone with access the ability “to have instantaneous visual access to certain taxpayer accounts.”

DOGE is operating as a unit within the new administration that President Trump has tasked with cutting spending and regulations.

Those with knowledge of DOGE's attempt to access IRS records said that, as of Monday morning, access had yet to be given, but one of the people said it was being considered by some in the agency as an urgent goal by the DOGE team.

Some Democrats have warned about risks to taxpayers if DOGE is allowed to access sensitive information without legal guardrails.

Lily Batchelder, who led Treasury's Office of Tax Policy during the Biden administration

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- ◆ **Deep staff cuts made at clean-energy program....** A4
- ◆ **Return-to-office order threatens union power... A4**
- ◆ **DOJ pushes dismissal of ethics watchdog.....** A5

INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL

Thrifty couples sprint to the altar to try to save money on their weddings. **A16**

BUSINESS NEWS

More Western tech companies move to shift production away from China. **B3**

Toothbrush Makers Are Sure You're Doing It All Wrong

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Designers chase elusive goal of two minutes, seek ‘meaningful and different’ experience

By NATASHA KHAN

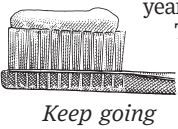
Eduardo Jiménez has thousands of toothbrushes. He compliments strangers on their smiles, then asks them about their dental regime. Family and friends know not to get him started about their oral habits because he may not stop.

At work he really obsesses. Jiménez, director of technology at Colgate-Palmolive, carries buckets of toothbrushes to meetings. He studies the angle of bristles and their corresponding scrubbing. He pores over data from

focus groups about the width of the handle and the all-important gripping point where a user's thumb and fingers hold the brush. Sometimes he brushes at his desk.

He is on a mission that has eluded Big Toothbrush for years: the two-minute clean. That is the amount of time dentists say it takes, twice a day, for adequate plaque removal. The problem is people tend to fall way short—focus groups show that even people who say they brush for two minutes actually do so for about 45 seconds.

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Released Gaza Hostages Face Long, Wrenching Recoveries

Nightmares, injuries and survivor's guilt haunt former captives for months after being freed; ‘my body is still tense’

By CARRIE KELLER-LYNN AND DAVID LUHNOW

SHEFAYIM, Israel—Five-year-old Uriah Brodutch was asked recently by his kindergarten teaching assistant whether he'd had any dreams lately. Yes, the boy said, he had dreamed about men taking him away from his home and killing other people.

Palestinian gunmen had kidnapped Uriah, his older brother Yuval, 9, and sister Ofri, 11, on Oct. 7, 2023, along with their mother, Hagar, and Abigail, a now 4-year-old girl from their kibbutz who had turned up at their family home that morning covered in her father's blood. Both of her parents were dead.

The Brodutch family and Abigail were held captive for nearly two months before they were released. More than a year later, they all

remain scarred by the trauma.

Uriah's father, Avihai, was wounded fighting gunmen that day but escaped from the kidnappers. His young son, Avihai said, recounted his violent dream “like it's just a fact of life. He wasn't crying. It just seems normal for him.”

“So many people died around him, and he was taken to Gaza,” Avihai said. “They saw bodies everywhere, and houses in flames. A lot of my friends and neighbors who we knew well had their families killed. So it's a part of our life now: death.”

On Saturday, three more hostages, including American-Israeli Sagui Dekel Chen, 36,

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◆ **Israeli forces extend stay in Lebanon.....** A8

For Thousands, Border Is Just a Daily Commute

By HARRIET TORRY

EL PASO, Texas—President Trump's tariff threats are injecting economic tension along the border that slices between two busy cities here.

For many workers and businesses, that barrier barely exists.

Near the junction of Texas, New Mexico and the Mexican state of Chihuahua, manufactured goods ranging from vehicle components to consumer appliances often crisscross the border multiple times during production and assembly. Thousands of people come from Mexico every day, too, on their way to work on the U.S. side.

“The bridge is simply that—a bridge,” said Gustavo Farell, president of Cesar-Scott,

which has manufacturing plants in El Paso and Ciudad Juárez making wire harnesses and cable assemblies for products such as industrial equipment and HVAC units. Nearly half of his two-dozen El Paso workers start their day across the Rio Grande, which Mexico calls the Rio Bravo.

Farell has been sweating out the Trump administration's threat to impose 25% tariffs on imports from Mexico and Canada. Companies and economists in Texas fear blanket tariffs on components, which have largely crossed the border duty-free for decades under free-trade deals, will put border manufacturers out of business.

“We buy products from

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